

133. Of all the days in the year, the one which they celebrate most is their birthday. It is customary to have the board furnished on that day with an ampler supply than common. The richer Persians cause an ox, a horse, a camel, and an ass to be baked whole⁸ and so served up to them: the poorer classes use instead the smaller kinds of cattle. They eat little solid food but abundance of dessert, which is set on table a few dishes at a time; this it is which makes them say that "the Greeks, when they eat, leave off hungry, having nothing worth mention served up to them after the meats; whereas, if they had more put before them, they would not stop eating." They are very fond of wine, and drink it in large quantities.⁹ To vomit or obey natural calls in the presence of another, is forbidden among them. Such are their customs in these matters.

It is also their general practice to deliberate upon affairs of weight when they are drunk; and then on the morrow, when they are sober, the decision to which they came the night before is put before them by the master of the house in which it was made; and if it is then approved of, they act on it; if not, they set it aside. Sometimes, however, they are sober at their first deliberation, but in this case they always reconsider the matter under the influence of wine.¹

places in the circle to receive the share allotted to them, which is further accompanied by a blessing and a prayer. It is only the initiated who are admitted to these meetings, and care is taken to guard against the intrusion of strangers and Mohammedans. It is probably, indeed, owing to the precaution which the Ali Allahis take to extinguish their lights on the approach of strangers that they have acquired the name of *Cheragh kushan*, or "lamp-extinguishers," and that orgies have been assigned to them which were only suited to darkness. A disciple, I may add, upon entering the brotherhood, breaks a nutmeg with the spiritual teacher to whom he attaches himself, and wears perpetually about him in token of his dependence, the half of the nut which remains with him; he is called *sir supurdeh*, or "he who has given over his head," and is bound during his noviciate implicitly to follow the behests of his leader. After a probationary discipline of several years, never less than three, he is admitted to a meeting, resigns his nutmeg, partakes of the sacrifice, and henceforward assumes a place among the initiated.—[H. C. R.]

⁸ It is a common custom in the East, at the present day, to roast sheep whole, even for an ordinary repast; and on fête days it is done in Dalmatia and in other parts of Europe.—[G. W.]

⁹ At the present day, among the "bons vivants" of Persia, it is usual to sit for hours before dinner drinking wine and eating dried fruits, such as filberts, almonds, pistachio-nuts, melon-seeds, &c. A party, indeed, often sits down at seven o'clock, and the dinner is not brought in till eleven. The dessert dishes, intermingled as they are with highly-seasoned delicacies, are supposed to have the effect of stimulating the appetite, but, in reality, the solid dishes, which are served up at the end of the feast, are rarely tasted. The passion, too, for wine-drinking is as marked among the Persians of the present day, notwithstanding the prohibitions of the Prophet, as it was in the time of Herodotus. It is quite appalling, indeed, to see the quantity of liquor which some of these toppers habitually consume, and they usually prefer spirits to wine.—[H. C. R.]

¹ Tacitus asserts that the Germans were in the habit of deliberating on peace